

plot of ground. The well was drilled—and a fair profit was eventually realized on the unusual operation.

I recall other memorable strikes during the 1920s.

Among them is the one I made in the so-called Athens Field in the southern suburbs of Los Angeles. I acquired the plot in question for something over \$12,000. Because I was operating entirely on my own account and knew that I would be stretching my available cash resources thin before completing the first well, I elected to act as my own drilling superintendent. Among the men I hired for my crew were three of the finest drillers in the oil industry: Walter Phillips, Oscar Prowell and "Spot" McMurdo. We completed the first well on February 16, 1925, at a depth of 4350 feet for an initial daily yield of 1500 barrels. A short while later, I brought in the second well on the site for an initial production of 2000 barrels per day. In the next nine years, the two wells on the Athens property were to show over \$400,000 excess recovery—clear profit over and above all costs and expenses.

Even more spectacular is the story of the Cleaver Lease in Alamitos Heights, which I bought with a personal check for \$8000 in October 1926 from a man who had purchased it for \$4000 only a few days before and who wanted to make a quick profit.

I spudded Well Number One on February 21, 1927, and subsequently drilled three more wells on the property. All

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proved exceptional producers, bringing up a total of more than 17,000 barrels daily. Between 1927 and 1939, excess recovery on the Cleaver Lease wells was nearly \$800,000—

a 10,000-percent profit on my original investment. Yet, within a few weeks after the first well came in, I was not only close to losing a fortune, but also close to losing the lease itself. Behind this apparent paradox lie two stories.